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AGENTS UNDER SUPERVISION

Deploying agentic AI in GCC banks under the new wave of AI rules

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Figures in this paper are drawn from regulators, central banks, standard setters and published industry research; each is referenced to the source list at the end. Views and recommendations are those of ATS5E Research.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

In 2026, AI governance in GCC finance stopped being a matter of good intentions and became a matter of supervision. The Central Bank of the UAE issued its guidance note on responsible AI in February, setting out three oversight models and making clear that banks remain accountable for AI they outsource ¹. Saudi Arabia's SDAIA published a national AI risk management framework built on a structured likelihood-impact matrix ⁶. The EU fixed new high-risk deadlines that reach any GCC bank scoring credit for EU customers ⁵, and the Financial Stability Board consulted on twelve sound practices for AI in financial institutions ⁷.

The timing matters because AI in the region is no longer confined to chatbots and pilots. AI agents have started to initiate payments in the UAE ¹²¹³, banks are now ranked publicly on AI capability ⁸, and at least one major Islamic bank has appointed a Chief AI Officer specifically to deploy generative and agentic AI ¹⁰. Yet the DFSA found that more than a fifth of DIFC firms lack clear accountability for AI ³.

Our view is that most banks will respond by treating governance as a gate: a committee that approves or rejects each use case. That approach will not scale to agents that act continuously, and it helps explain why Gartner expects more than 40% of agentic AI projects to be cancelled by the end of 2027 ¹⁴. The banks that win will instead build a **supervisable agent architecture**: a live inventory with risk tiers mapped to the CBUAE oversight models, decision logging and explainability by design, human-on-the-loop operations, clear accountability for third-party AI, and bilingual disclosure. This paper sets out that architecture, a four-level maturity model and a 90-day, six-month and twelve-month agenda tied to the ATS5E 5E framework.

00 · KEY FINDINGS

THE NUMBERS THAT MATTER

The evidence behind the argument, drawn from regulators, operators and published research. Superscripts refer to the source list.

21%

of DIFC firms lack clear accountability for AI, even as adoption reached 52% ³

40%+

of agentic AI projects expected to be cancelled by the end of 2027 ¹⁴

6%

of anti-fraud professionals confident explaining AI decisions, though 82% prioritise explainability ¹⁷

2 Dec 2027

new EU AI Act deadline for stand-alone high-risk systems, including credit scoring ⁵

01

THE YEAR AI GOVERNANCE BECAME SUPERVISORY

Between February and September 2026, GCC banks moved from writing their own AI principles to answering a supervisor's questions about them.

For most of the past decade, AI governance in Gulf banking was voluntary. Banks wrote ethics statements, formed working groups and approved pilots case by case. That era has ended. The rules now arriving are not yet prescriptive rulebooks, but they are specific enough that a supervisor can ask a bank to show how it complies, and a bank that cannot will struggle to explain itself.

THE CBUAE SETS THE TERMS IN THE UAE

The CBUAE's guidance note on consumer protection and the responsible adoption of AI, issued in February 2026, is principles-based ¹. It is organised around governance and accountability, fairness, transparency and explainability, human oversight, and data management and privacy ². Three features matter most for agentic AI. First, it describes three oversight models: **human in the loop**, **human on the loop** and **human out of the loop**, with the last reserved for low-risk processes ¹. Second, it gives customers rights to an explanation, to challenge and to redress, and expects disclosures in Arabic and English ¹. Third, licensed financial institutions remain accountable for AI that is outsourced to third parties ¹.

The guidance sits inside a wider tightening. The new Central Bank law makes responsible managers personally liable under Article 181, and AI and machine-learning guidance is listed among the CBUAE's 2026 regulatory output alongside new remuneration, telemarketing and insurance-licensing rules ¹⁸. The CBUAE's operational risk regulation, effective 14 September 2026, requires notification within four hours of an incident that significantly affects critical operations ¹⁹. An agent that fails in a critical process is an operational risk event, not an innovation-lab problem.

52%

of DIFC firms using AI in 2025, up from 33% in 2024 ³

21%

of DIFC firms lacking clear AI accountability ³

The DFSA's 2025 AI survey, with 661 respondents, shows why supervisors are paying attention: 52% of DIFC firms now use AI, up from 33% a year earlier, while 21% lack clear accountability for it ³. For a bank executive, the implication is direct. Adoption is outpacing ownership, and the first supervisory conversations will focus on who is accountable, not on which model is used.

SAUDI ARABIA, THE EU AND THE FSB

In Saudi Arabia, SDAIA's National AI Risk Management Framework, published in 2026, introduces a staged risk cycle, a four-by-four likelihood-impact matrix and seven risk categories ⁶. It gives Saudi banks a common vocabulary for scoring AI risk, and it will be easier to comply with if the bank's AI inventory is already structured around likelihood and impact.

GCC banks with EU customers or operations must also track the EU AI Act. Under the Digital Omnibus, which received final Council approval on 29 June 2026 ⁴, stand-alone high-risk systems listed in Annex III, which include creditworthiness assessment and credit scoring, now face a deadline of 2 December 2027; AI embedded in products moves to 2 August 2028 ⁵. The Article 50 transparency obligations are unaffected and proceed as scheduled, while the AI-literacy duty has been softened ⁵. The delay is a planning window, not a reprieve.

Finally, the FSB consulted in June 2026 on twelve sound practices for the responsible adoption of AI by financial institutions; comments closed on 22 July and a final report is expected in October 2026 ⁷. International standard-setters tend to shape how national supervisors frame their expectations, so GCC banks should treat the final report as a preview of future questions.

The question has shifted from whether a bank has AI principles to whether it can prove, for any agent on any day, who was watching and why the agent acted.

ATS5E RESEARCH

WHAT LEADERS SHOULD DO

- Name a single accountable executive for AI and record it in the governance framework, closing the gap the DFSA survey exposed.
- Map every existing AI use case to one of the three CBUAE oversight models and document the rationale.
- Identify any credit models that touch EU customers and plan against the 2 December 2027 deadline now.
- Treat agent failures in critical processes as operational risk incidents with the same reporting discipline.

02

AGENTS ARE ALREADY TRANSACTING

Agentic AI in the Gulf has moved from demonstration to live payments, and banks are now competing publicly on AI capability.

The regulatory shift would matter less if AI remained advisory. It no longer does. In December 2025 Visa reported that it was working with Aldar so that UAE customers can use AI agents to pay recurring real-estate service charges, part of a programme with hundreds of agent-initiated transactions and more than 100 partners ¹². Visa said it expects millions of consumers to use agents by the 2026 holiday season ¹². Mastercard has announced the launch of Agent Pay in the UAE with Majid Al Futtaim, starting with VOX Cinemas ¹³.

These are payments initiated by software acting for a customer. Every question the CBUAE guidance raises, from explanation and challenge to disclosure and outsourced accountability, applies with more force when an agent moves money. Banks will be asked to authorise, monitor and, where necessary, reverse actions that no human directly took.

BANKS ARE COMPETING ON AI IN PUBLIC

The inaugural Evident AI Index for Banks in the Middle East and Africa, published in June 2026, ranked Emirates NBD first of 25 banks, with Standard Bank, FAB and Nedbank close behind, all within one point on a 100-point scale ⁸. FAB led the Transparency pillar ⁸. The index scores Talent, Innovation, Leadership and Transparency, which means governance and disclosure are now part of competitive standing, not only compliance.

#1 of 25

Emirates NBD in the inaugural Evident AI Index for Banks, MEA ⁸

~50%

regional AI-development talent pool relative to global bank benchmarks ⁹

14 of 25

indexed banks contributed to their national AI strategy ⁹

Evident also found that the region's AI-development talent pool is about half the size of global bank benchmarks, that the 25 banks documented more than 50 AI use cases over two years, and that 14 of the 25 contributed to their national AI strategy ⁹. The talent gap matters for governance: banks cannot staff a review committee for every agent decision, so oversight must be engineered into the platform.

Leadership is moving accordingly. ADIB appointed Pedro Uria-Recio, formerly of CIMB, as Chief AI Officer in August 2026 to deploy generative and agentic AI, at a bank with 2.7 million customers and 94% of transactions already digital ¹⁰. Emirates NBD has been reported as partnering with Techstars on start-ups focused on agentic finance ¹¹.

30%

potential uplift in retail-bank profitability from AI agents by 2030, with costs cut by 30-40%, according to BCG ¹⁵

The economic case is substantial. BCG estimates that AI agents could raise retail-bank profitability by 30% and cut costs by 30-40% by 2030 ¹⁵. The prize explains the urgency; the regulation explains why the prize will only go to banks that can show supervisors how their agents are controlled.

WHAT LEADERS SHOULD DO

- Assume customers will arrive with third-party agents acting on their behalf, and decide how the bank will authenticate, limit and log them.
- Put the Chief AI Officer or equivalent in charge of both agent delivery and agent supervision, so the two are designed together.
- Treat transparency as a competitive asset: publish how the bank governs AI, in Arabic and English.

03

WHY GOVERNANCE AS A GATE WILL FAIL

A committee that approves use cases one by one cannot supervise agents that act continuously.

Faced with new rules, the instinctive response is to add a checkpoint. A use case is written up, reviewed by risk, compliance and technology, approved with conditions and then released. This model worked, imperfectly, for static scoring models that changed a few times a year. It breaks down for agents, for three reasons.

WHERE THE GATE MODEL BREAKS

- **Agents change behaviour after approval.** They call tools, combine data and act across systems; the risk sits in what they do in production, not in the design document.
- **Gates do not produce evidence.** An approval memo does not tell a supervisor, or a customer exercising a right to challenge, why a specific action was taken on a specific day.
- **Gates create queues.** With a talent pool about half the size of global benchmarks ⁹, review capacity becomes the bottleneck and projects stall or bypass the process.

40%+

of agentic AI projects that Gartner expects to be cancelled by the end of 2027 ¹⁴

Gartner expects more than 40% of agentic AI projects to be cancelled by the end of 2027 ¹⁴. In our view, the likeliest route to cancellation in regulated banking is predictable: a pilot succeeds, the control requirements for production are discovered late, and the cost of retrofitting logging, oversight and disclosure exceeds the expected benefit.

THE PROBLEM IS CULTURE AS MUCH AS TOOLING

Gartner's September 2026 survey of 223 data and analytics leaders found that culture, not funding, is the main reason governance fails, and predicts that by 2027, 60% of organisations that ignore data governance culture will fail to govern AI successfully ¹⁶. A gate reinforces the wrong culture: governance becomes someone else's job, performed after the build. Supervisable agents require the opposite, where product teams own their controls and risk teams set standards and test them.

The explainability gap shows the same pattern. In the ACFE and SAS 2026 benchmarking study of 713 anti-fraud professionals, 82% said they prioritise explainability, yet only 6% were confident explaining AI decisions¹⁷. Stated priorities do not translate into capability unless explanation is designed into how the system records its decisions.

60%

of organisations ignoring data governance culture predicted to fail to govern AI by 2027¹⁶

6%

of anti-fraud professionals confident explaining AI decisions¹⁷

Governance that arrives after the build is a cost. Governance built into the agent is what lets it reach production.

ATS5E RESEARCH

WHAT LEADERS SHOULD DO

- Replace one-off approvals with standards that every agent must meet by design, and test them continuously.
- Make product owners accountable for their agents' controls; make second-line risk accountable for setting and checking the standard.
- Stop any agent pilot that has no named path to production-grade logging and oversight.

04

THE SUPERVISABLE AGENT ARCHITECTURE

Five components turn regulatory principles into controls a bank can operate and a supervisor can inspect.

A supervisable agent is one whose purpose, permissions, risk tier, oversight model and decision history can be shown on demand. Building one is less about new models and more about disciplined data, process and platform engineering. We see five components.

1. AGENT INVENTORY AND RISK TIERING

Every agent, whether built in-house, embedded in a vendor product or accessed through a partner, is registered with its owner, purpose, data sources, tools it can call and actions it can take. Each is scored for risk; in Saudi Arabia the SDAIA four-by-four likelihood-impact matrix and its seven risk categories provide a ready scale ⁶. The risk tier then determines the CBUAE oversight model: human out of the loop only for low-risk processes ¹, human on the loop for supervised operations and human in the loop where an outcome materially affects a customer.

2. DECISION LOGGING AND EXPLAINABILITY BY DESIGN

Each agent action writes a structured record: the inputs, the data used, the tools called, the reason codes, the model version and the human, if any, who approved or reviewed it. This is what makes the customer's rights to explanation, challenge and redress practicable ¹. A governed data platform such as Microsoft Fabric can hold these records alongside the business data they reference, so that lineage and explanation come from the same source.

3. HUMAN-ON-THE-LOOP OPERATIONS

Most agents in a bank will sit in the middle model: acting within limits while people watch. That requires an operations function with dashboards, thresholds, sampling, escalation routes and the ability to pause an agent immediately. Orchestration tools such as UiPath can route exceptions from agents to people and back. Where an agent supports a critical operation, its incident runbook should align with the four-hour notification requirement in the CBUAE's operational risk regulation ¹⁹.

4. THIRD-PARTY AND OUTSOURCED AI ACCOUNTABILITY

Because banks remain accountable for outsourced AI ¹, every vendor model and every external agent that interacts with the bank belongs in the inventory. Contracts need rights to logs, notice of model changes and exit plans. This applies equally to platforms used for financial-crime analytics or reconciliations and to

customer-side agents arriving through card networks.

5. BILINGUAL DISCLOSURE

The CBUAE expects disclosures in Arabic and English ¹. Disclosure templates should be versioned, tied to the agent's inventory record and tested with customers in both languages, so that what the bank tells customers matches what the agent actually does.

OBLIGATION	WHAT IT ASKS FOR	CONTROL IN A SUPERVISABLE AGENT ARCHITECTURE
CBUAE: human in the loop	Human decision on outcomes that materially affect customers	Agent drafts, a named person decides; approver identity and rationale written to the decision log
CBUAE: human on the loop	Human oversight of agents acting within limits	Supervision console, thresholds, sampling, escalation routes and an immediate pause control
CBUAE: human out of the loop	Permitted only for low-risk processes	Documented low-risk classification, periodic re-attestation and automated monitoring for drift
CBUAE: explanation, challenge, redress	Customers can ask why, contest and obtain a remedy	Reason codes captured at decision time; complaints process retrieves the decision record
CBUAE: Arabic and English disclosure	Clear bilingual disclosure to customers	Versioned bilingual disclosure templates linked to each agent's inventory entry
CBUAE: outsourced AI	The bank remains accountable	Third-party AI register, contractual log access, change notification and exit plans
SDAIA risk framework	Staged risk cycle, 4x4 likelihood-impact matrix, seven risk categories	Inventory scored on the matrix; tier drives oversight model and review frequency
EU AI Act, Annex III	High-risk obligations for credit scoring by 2 December 2027	Identify EU-exposed credit models; assemble evidence packs from decision logs
EU AI Act, Article 50	Transparency obligations proceeding as scheduled	AI-interaction disclosure built into digital channels
FSB sound practices	Twelve practices; final report expected October 2026	Benchmark the control framework against the final report on publication

ATS5E mapping of emerging AI obligations to supervisable-agent controls. Sources: ^{1 5 6 7}

WHAT LEADERS SHOULD DO

- Stand up the agent inventory before scaling any agent further; include vendor and partner agents.
- Define the decision-log schema once, centrally, and make it a condition of production release.
- Build a human-on-the-loop operations capability with clear staffing, thresholds and pause authority.

05

MATURITY, AND THE SOVEREIGN FOUNDATION

Most GCC banks sit at the first or second level today; the goal is supervision at scale on infrastructure that meets residency expectations.

The table below sets out a four-level maturity model. It is a diagnostic tool, not a certification: most banks will find different business lines at different levels, and the aim is to move the highest-risk agents first.

LEVEL	INVENTORY AND TIERING	OVERSIGHT	EVIDENCE	ACCOUNTABILITY
1. Experimental	Spreadsheet of pilots, if any	Informal; developers watch outputs	Ad hoc logs, not retained	Unclear; sits with project sponsors
2. Gated	Approved use cases listed; no risk scoring	Committee approval before launch	Approval memos, not decision records	Committee owns decisions; product teams do not
3. Supervised	Live inventory incl. vendor agents; risk-tiered	Oversight model assigned per tier; on-the-loop operations for key agents	Structured decision logs with reason codes	Named owner per agent; accountable executive for AI
4. Supervisable at scale	Inventory drives release, monitoring and review automatically	Continuous monitoring, pause controls and periodic re-tiering	Evidence packs produced on demand for supervisors and customers	Controls owned by product teams, tested by second line

ATS5E supervisable-agent maturity model

RESIDENCY AND SOVEREIGN COMPUTE

Decision logs and the data behind them are sensitive, and where they are stored is becoming a supervisory question. The CBUAE and Core42 launched a sovereign financial cloud in February 2026 as part of the CBUAE's Financial Infrastructure Transformation programme ²¹, and legal commentators note that data residency, supervisory access and resilience duties are becoming increasingly operational as a result ²⁰. In Saudi Arabia, SDAIA issued 48 enforcement decisions over about a year, with financial services among the sectors affected ²⁵.

Regional compute capacity is growing but uneven. Microsoft has committed US\$15.2bn to the UAE between 2023 and 2029, including 200MW of Azure capacity via Khazna from 2026 ²³. Stargate UAE is planned as a 1GW cluster within a 5GW UAE-US AI campus, with the first 200MW planned for 2026 ²². In Saudi Arabia, HUMAIN targets 1.9GW by 2030, against national capacity of 467MW in the first quarter of 2026 ²⁴. Banks should design agent platforms so that models, logs and data can run where residency rules require, rather than assuming a single location.

Where an agent's decision record lives is now as important as what it records.

ATS5E RESEARCH

WHAT LEADERS SHOULD DO

- Assess each business line against the maturity model and move the highest-risk agents to Level 3 first.
- Classify decision logs as regulated data, with residency and supervisory-access requirements defined up front.
- Keep the agent platform portable across in-country cloud options so residency changes do not force a rebuild.

06

THE SUPERVISABLE AGENT AGENDA

NEXT 90 DAYS

01 EXECUTION: NAME OWNERS AND BUILD THE INVENTORY

Appoint an accountable executive for AI, register every internal, vendor and partner agent, and assign each a risk tier and a CBUAE oversight model.

02 EMPOWERMENT: SET THE STANDARD, NOT THE QUEUE

Publish minimum control standards for any agent entering production and give product teams ownership of meeting them, with second-line risk testing compliance.

03 EVOLUTION: TRIAGE EU EXPOSURE

Identify credit and other Annex III systems that touch EU customers and plan against the 2 December 2027 deadline.

SIX MONTHS

04 EFFICIENCY: DECISION LOGGING BY DESIGN

Deploy a common decision-log schema on the bank's governed data platform and make it a release condition for all medium- and high-risk agents.

05 EXPERIENCE: BILINGUAL DISCLOSURE AND REDRESS

Launch versioned Arabic and English disclosures and a complaints route that retrieves the relevant decision record for explanation and challenge.

TWELVE MONTHS

06 EXECUTION: HUMAN-ON-THE-LOOP OPERATIONS

Run a staffed agent-supervision function with thresholds, sampling, pause authority and incident runbooks aligned to operational risk reporting.

07 EVOLUTION: REACH LEVEL 3 AND BENCHMARK

Move all high-risk agents to Level 3 maturity, benchmark controls against the FSB's final sound practices, and prepare supervisor-ready evidence packs.

METHODOLOGY & REFERENCES

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This paper draws on primary regulatory publications, official company announcements and published legal and analyst commentary available up to 30 September 2026. Where a source reported a development without our being able to read the primary document, we have phrased it as reported. Figures are cited as published and have not been adjusted. The maturity model, control mapping and recommendations are ATS5E's own analysis and do not represent the view of any regulator.

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INTELLIGENCE. APPLIED.

ATS5E partners with banks and financial institutions across the GCC to deliver data, AI, automation and cloud transformation — from strategy to production. Our 5E framework connects every engagement to measurable outcomes.

EXPERIENCE	EMPOWERMENT	EFFICIENCY	EXECUTION	EVOLUTION
Human-centred experiences for customers and employees.	AI-driven intelligence for smarter decisions at every level.	Intelligent automation that removes wasted effort.	Strategy delivered into results customers feel.	Modernisation without disruption.

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